

Self-Assessment and Goal Setting

Search vigilantly for the true, but often underlying, causes of failure on the rock—that's the ultimate secret to optimizing your training and taking your climbing to the next level.

The first step to improving your situation—in anything—can be expressed simply as “Know thyself.” You cannot progress beyond your current state with the same thoughts and actions that brought you here. Therefore, only through constant self-evaluation will you unlock the secrets to incremental improvement. For instance, you must actively distinguish what works from what does not work, as well as be able to recognize what you need to learn versus what must be unlearned. Often the key elements are not obvious or clear, but you must accept that life is subtle; only through improving on the little things will you succeed in the big things.

In climbing, the process of improvement begins with getting to know your patterns at the crags, in the gym, and in your everyday life. You must become aware of your climbing-related strengths and weaknesses in each area of the performance triad—technical, mental, and physical—and learn to leverage your strengths and improve upon the weaknesses. Toward this end, your prime directive must be to train intelligently—that is, to engage in training activities that best address your weaknesses, while not getting drawn into the trap of training as others do.

Of course, a clear understanding of your mega goals in this sport is equally important to achieving success. Only with a clear goal in mind can you take consistent actions that keep you on route, as

well as have the sense to recognize when you have wandered off route. Finally, at the very deepest level, you must closely examine your level of commitment to climbing—are you willing to make the sacrifices necessary for reaching your mega goals? This chapter will guide you through the fundamental steps of self-assessment and goal setting that, in turn, will initiate your ascent to becoming a better, more successful climber (no matter your gauge of measuring success).

Self-Assessment: The Breakfast of Champions

Identifying personal weaknesses often requires a paradigm shift—a dramatic change in the way we see things—because it's human nature to think about and practice the things at which we excel. Too many climbers (myself included) have wasted precious years practicing and training the things at which they already shine, while the ball-and-chain of their weaknesses holds them back. For instance, many climbers think “more strength” is the panacea to their climbing woes; but as shown in figure 1.1, it's just one piece of the climbing performance puzzle. It requires an awakening for most climbers to recognize the thoughts and life patterns that are really holding them back, and that their time and energy could be invested more productively elsewhere.

Introspection and curiosity are key attributes you must foster because, at least at the first superficial glance, your real-life experiences with failure on a climb will almost always appear to result

from a lack of strength. But what about all the underlying causes that may have led to premature fatigue—poor footwork, bad body positioning, overgripping of holds, climbing too slowly, scattered focus, a missed rest, unreasonable fears, or a lack of energy due to poor diet or dehydration? As you can see, the other two-thirds of the climbing performance puzzle (technical and mental) determine how effectively you use the physical strength and energy reserves you possess. Consequently, it's my belief that the average climber wastes 50 percent (or more!) of his strength and energy due to flawed technique, inefficient movement, and poor mental control. This is analogous to having a thirty-miles-per-gallon car that only gets fifteen miles per gallon as the result of a horrible tune-up and a heavy foot. Therefore, the average climber can obtain a huge windfall of relative strength gains—and dramatically improve performance—by training up technique, quality of movement, and mental control.

The moral of the story, then, is that the best training program for climbing must include lots of climbing and constant self-evaluation. Spending three or four days a week on the rock (or an artificial wall) deliberately practicing skills and refining your climber's mind-set is far more beneficial than spending those days strength training in the gym. This is not to say that you can simply climb a lot and ignore all the other facets of performance. The best climbers clearly focus on putting the complete puzzle together, and this undoubtedly includes a targeted strength-training program. Still, if you can do ten fingertip pull-ups, you are probably strong enough to climb most 5.12a routes! So search vigilantly for the true, but often underlying, causes of your failure on routes. That's the ultimate secret to optimizing your training program and establishing new personal bests on the rock.

Objective Evaluation

The best way to identify your weaknesses is to ask yourself a series of detailed questions. To identify

physical and technical weaknesses, ask yourself targeted questions like: *Do I fail on a route because I'm too weak or do I overgrip and hang out too long in the midst of hard moves? Does my footwork deteriorate in the moves prior to where I fall? Do I climb too slowly through crux moves and consequently come up short on routes? Do I lack the flexibility to step onto a crucial hold or do I miss a better, easier foot placement? Am I really too short for this move or have I failed to find the body position that makes it possible for someone my height?*

Some questions for identifying mental errors are: *Do I fail to see the sequence or do I fail to try something new when the obvious doesn't work? Do I try too hard or give up too easily? Am I controlling my internal self-talk or is the critic within doing a hatchet job on me? Do I monitor and control my body tension or does my perceived pressure of the situation run the show? Do I sabotage myself before leaving the ground by doubting my ability and pondering past failures?*

In addition to investigating yourself, consider enlisting a coach to provide an even more objective view of your performance or, at the least, have a friend shoot some video of you on the rock. These detached perspectives are especially useful in identifying obvious flaws in technique, tactics, and your overall economy of effort. For example, feet skidding or popping off footholds signals lack of attention to footwork, while constant stretching for holds seemingly just out of reach is a sign you're missing critical intermediate holds or using less effective body positions. In more general terms, evaluate whether your movement looks relaxed and fluid or appears tight, mechanical, and hesitant. These outside perspectives can be a real eye-opener, and you'll probably be surprised at what you find. Still, some fundamental mistakes and weaknesses are so subtle that they are not easily observed by others or by viewing yourself on video. This is where a detailed self-assessment test comes in handy.

Taking the Self-Assessment Test

A good self-assessment test takes the white light of your climbing performance and, like a prism, disassembles it into the rainbow of colors representing specific skills. The results will reveal your true (not perceived) strengths and weaknesses—and possibly even an unknown Achilles' heel that must be addressed if you are to ever reach your potential (or break through a long-term plateau). With this knowledge, you can create the most effective training program for you!

In taking the assessment that follows, it's important to read each question once and then

immediately answer it based on your recent experiences on the rock. Don't read anything into the questions; nor should you try to figure out their focus and shade your answers in any way. Instead of working in the book, consider making a photocopy of the test pages in order to maintain an unmarked self-assessment test with which to work (or copy again) in the future. Of course, it would be ideal to date your test and file it for future reference. Comparing successive self-assessments is a powerful way to track your long-term improvement in each area of the performance triad.

Exercise: Self-Assessment Test

Answer each question by circling the number that best characterizes your performance. To obtain the most accurate results, it's essential that you score each question according to your most recent experiences on the rock. Pause for a moment and review recent climbs to determine the correct answer for each question. Do not overanalyze the questions, however, or try to read between the lines—you will have a chance to ponder the meaning of your answers when you tally the final results.

0 = almost always

1 = often

2 = about half the time

3 = occasionally

4 = seldom

5 = never

1. My footwork (use of feet) deteriorates during the hardest part of a climb.

0 1 2 3 4 5

2. My forearms balloon and my grip begins to fail even on routes that are easy for me.

0 1 2 3 4 5

3. On hard sequences, I have difficulty stepping onto critical footholds.

0 1 2 3 4 5

4. I get anxious and tight as I head into crux sequences.

0 1 2 3 4 5

5. My biceps (upper arms) pump out before my forearms.

0 1 2 3 4 5

6. I have difficulty hanging on small, necessary-to-use holds.

0 1 2 3 4 5

7. I blow sequences I have wired and know by heart.

0 1 2 3 4 5

8. I stall at the start of crux sequences. I end up having to hang on the rope and rest before I can give it a good, solid try.

0 1 2 3 4 5

9. I climb three or four days in a row.

0 1 2 3 4 5

10. I get sewing-machine leg ("Elvis leg").

0 1 2 3 4 5

11. I pump out on overhanging climbs no matter how big the holds.

0 1 2 3 4 5

12. I get out of breath when I climb.

0 1 2 3 4 5

13. I make excuses for why I might fail on a route before I even begin to climb.

0 1 2 3 4 5

14. I miss hidden holds on routes.

0 1 2 3 4 5

15. I have difficulty hanging on to sloping holds, pockets, and/or pinches.

0 1 2 3 4 5

16. I grab quickdraws, the rope, or other gear instead of risking a fall trying a hard move of which I am unsure.

0 1 2 3 4 5

17. On a typical climb, I feel like much of my body weight is hanging on my arms.

0 1 2 3 4 5

18. I get very sore the day after climbing at the crags.

0 1 2 3 4 5

19. I have difficulty visualizing myself successfully climbing the route before I leave the ground.

0 1 2 3 4 5

20. I cannot reach key holds on difficult routes.

0 1 2 3 4 5

21. On overhanging routes and roofs, I have difficulty keeping my feet from cutting loose and swinging out.

0 1 2 3 4 5

22. While climbing, I get distracted by activity on the ground and/or I think about whether the belayer is paying attention.

0 1 2 3 4 5

23. I have difficulty reading sequences.

0 1 2 3 4 5

24. I get a flash pump on the first climb of the day.

0 1 2 3 4 5

25. I have more difficulty climbing when people are watching.

0 1 2 3 4 5

26. My feet unexpectedly pop off footholds.

0 1 2 3 4 5

27. I experience elbow or shoulder pain when I train or climb on a regular basis.

0 1 2 3 4 5

28. When lead climbing a safe route, I have difficulty pushing myself to the complete limit.

0 1 2 3 4 5

29. I have difficulty finding mid-route rest positions and shakeouts.

0 1 2 3 4 5

30. My first attempt on a hard route is usually better than my second or third attempts of the day.

0 1 2 3 4 5

Table 2.1 Score Yourself

Mental	Technique and Tactics	Physical
1.	2.	3.
4.	5.	6.
7.	8.	9.
10.	11.	12.
13.	14.	15.
16.	17.	18.
19.	20.	21.
22.	23.	24.
25.	26.	27.
28.	29.	30.
(Total)	(Total)	(Total)

Looking at Your Test Results

Record the scores from each question in table 2.1, and then add up each column to obtain a final score for each area of the performance triad. Compare your mental, technical, and physical scores to gain a sense of which area is your strong or weak aspect of the performance triad. If all three areas are within five points of one another, congratulate yourself for being a climber of balanced abilities. It is more common, however, to discover that one aspect of performance is much lower-scoring than the other two. This area is your major weakness, and the most effective training program for you is one that targets this area for improvement.

Next, review each question of the self-assessment test and mark a star next to those on which you scored a 3 or less. Each of these low-scoring questions identifies a specific element of your climbing performance that is holding you back. List on a separate piece of paper or in your training log a brief description of each problem

revealed. Sort and group them according to the aspects of the performance triad. As you read through the remainder of the book, keep this list of problem areas nearby, and make notes of the exercises and strategies presented that address these weaknesses. Creating such a written “mind map” that displays both the problem areas and the action-oriented solutions will keep these highly powerful keys to better climbing in the forefront of your attention. Only with this awareness will your training remain on track and effective in the weeks and months to come.

As you move into the goal-setting exercises later in this chapter, refer back to the self-assessment test or your summary mind map. Focus your short- and medium-term training goals on the most dramatic weaknesses identified (the five or six lowest-scoring items). As you recognize improvement in these areas, shift your training focus onto other lower-scoring areas of the self-assessment or retake the entire test and develop a new training strategy based

on the new results. For additional training tips that address each question of the self-assessment, see appendix C.

The Cycle of Improvement

Your completed self-assessment is your “boarding pass” to the Cycle of Improvement. This process cycle has three stages: Set goals, take action, and make course corrections (see figure 2.1).

A successful trip around the cycle gives birth to a new level of climbing performance—the Cycle of Improvement, in fact, becomes a Spiral of Improvement! Occasionally, reassessments are needed to update your goals relative to the “new you” and whatever new issues are now responsible for holding you back from further improvement. These new goals give birth to new actions and even more spectacular results.

Figure 2.1 Cycle of Improvement



Use this three-step process to elevate your performance to the next level.

Depending on your desires, commitment, and skill level, one trip around the cycle may take anywhere from a couple of months to a year. Signs that you are ready for a reassessment and a new cycle include a plateau in performance, training that feels flat, or a drop in motivation. If you experience more than one of these signs, take a week or two off, then retake the self-assessment test and start a new cycle.

Remember that there is a big difference between employing the Cycle of Improvement and just going climbing year-round. The latter approach is unfocused and will yield slow results and frequent plateaus in performance. Conversely, a deliberate effort in all three stages—setting new goals, taking intelligent action, and making appropriate course corrections—keeps the spiral going upward toward your ultimate genetic potential.

Goal Setting

Defining specific goals enables you to perform a gap analysis of what actions you must take to bridge the gap (or possibly chasm) between where you are now and what you want to become or achieve. Effective goal setting begins with a pen or pencil and a calendar, training log, or climbing notebook. If you don’t write down your goals, chances are they will remain intangible hopes and dreams that never materialize.

It’s best to set goals in three time frames: short-term (daily), medium-term (weekly or monthly), and long-term (yearly or “career”) goals. Write down the goals in precise terms and with realistic deadlines. And since pictures are even more motivating than words on paper, it’s crucial to create a mental picture (representing the goal) that you can recall in your mind’s eye on demand. The more precise and focused your picture and written goal, the easier it will be for you to zero in on the target and take actions that will someday lead you to realize the goal.

Next, create a mission statement that summarizes the purpose of each goal-setting time frame, such as “Short term, I will strive for the most effective ninety-minute workout possible” or “Medium term, I am committed to climbing my first 5.12 (V6, or whatever) by the end of the summer.” Now share these goals with your climbing partner, a close friend, or significant other—someone who will hold you accountable and help motivate you to stay on mission.

Finally, write down what one or two (or more) things you will give up in order to reach your short-, medium-, and long-term goals. This vital step is missing from most conventional goal-setting exercises, and it may be the number one reason why so many people fail to achieve their big goals in life. It’s a fact that you cannot add something new and achieve the ideal outcome without sacrificing something else in its place. Ponder this powerful idea. It may explain why some of your past or present goals remain elusive.

SHORT-TERM GOALS

Short-term goals define your daily game plan. They help focus your thoughts and actions so that you are not swayed by what others are doing and don’t waste precious time on less important activities (TV, partying, surfing the Net, excessive socializing). The more hectic your life, the more crucial it is that you spend a few minutes before bed or first thing in the morning doing some short-term goal setting. Folks with less difficult daily schedules may only need to set short-term goals relating to the workout du jour. Begin by writing down the primary mission of the workout, then list the specific exercises, sets, and reps as well as the approximate amount of time you will dedicate to each part of the workout (see “An Example of Short-Term Goal Setting” below). Don’t forget to list what you will give up (relative to previous days or your peers) in order to fulfill these short-term commitments.

MEDIUM-TERM GOALS

Medium-term goals give shape and direction to your schedule over the course of weeks and months. This planning is best done on a calendar so you can effectively dovetail your workouts and climbing trips with your other nonclimbing activities. Try to roughly plan things out a few months in advance (see the “Setting Medium-Term Goals” exercise below).

First, block in the big events such as climbing trips, competitions, work and family obligations, and the like. Next, write in your proposed workout and climbing schedule, with special attention to maintaining enough rest days in the game plan. With the most important items now in place, you can fill in the many little, less important things in life where time allows (or this can be done on an ad hoc basis). Remember to sum up your medium-term goals with one overriding primary goal, as well as listing the activities you will forfeit in order to attain this lofty goal.

LONG-TERM GOALS

Long-term goal setting is a fun and invaluable activity in which you condense onto paper the numerous “dream” or “I wish” goals floating around in your mind. If there is to be any chance of them ever becoming reality, it’s vital that they be liberated from the dreamland of your mind and put down in black and white (see the “Setting Long-Term Goals” exercise below). A magical force begins to act in your life when you write down these mega goals—your subconscious mind will go to work day and night on achieving them, and your conscious mind will suddenly find them more believable (and achievable).

An Example of Short-Term Goal Setting

Today's Mission:

Focus on improving my footwork and conserving energy by practicing skills and techniques.

What I will give up to achieve this goal:

The usual bouldering games and competitions at the gym.

For today, I'll stay off all routes that are beyond my on-site ability.

I won't rush home to watch TV.

What I will do:

1. Warm up with fifteen minutes of light bouldering, gentle stretching, and two sets of pull-ups.
2. Perform ten to fifteen minutes of the traverse-training drill with focus on light grip, precise footwork, and smooth movement.
3. Toprope several climbs within one number grade of my limit with the focus on practicing technique, not performance outcome (whether or not I fall). My practice goals are to concentrate on careful positioning and use of each foothold; to climb as briskly, smoothly, and decisively as possible between rests; to accurately read sequences before leaving the ground and while at each rest position; and to remain positive, relaxed, and centered during each climb.
4. Perform three sets of six repetitions of the One-Arm Lunging exercise.
5. Perform three sets of weighted pull-ups with ten pounds.
6. Perform a minimum of ten minutes of wrist, rotator cuff, and scapular stabilizer training.
7. Cool down with five to ten minutes of stretching.
8. Eat a good meal within one to two hours after the workout.
9. Get seven to eight hours of sleep.

Exercise: Setting Medium-Term Goals

Your medium-term goals can include both climbing and nonclimbing items; we'll focus on the climbing-related goals here. Write down your top training goals (mental, physical, and technical) for the next three months, as well as a few climbing goals such as to-do routes or new areas to visit. Distill these goals into a single primary goal for the period, and remember to list a few things you will freely give up in order to reach these goals.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There is no text or other markings on the paper.

Exercise: Setting Long-Term Goals

Go somewhere quiet, allow yourself to relax for a few minutes, and then ponder what long-term mega goals would really energize you and make for an exceptional journey. I call these mega goals because they are the few events that you most want to achieve in your life given your current perspective. For example, you might have an ultimate grade of climbing you'd like to achieve, or possibly a specific dream climb to send or mountain to summit. Think about where you'd go if time and money were not an issue—put it down on paper and the odds increase a thousandfold that you will someday be pulling down there! By all means write down a few of your nonclimbing mega goals as well, but keep the total list down to between six and eight items.

As in setting your short- and medium-term goals, it's absolutely critical that you write down a couple of major things that you will completely give up in order to reach these mega goals. Consider the activities, possessions, and people that drain your time, focus, and energy.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue or grey ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There is no handwriting or other markings on the paper.

Taking Action and Making Course Corrections

The Cycle of Improvement will spiral you upward in ability as long as the actions taken provide movement toward your goals. Sadly, taking consistent, disciplined action in the direction of worthy goals is very difficult for some people. The results of their misdirected actions always seem to leave them in an all-too-familiar situation. The phrase *same shit, different day* is born of this affliction.

If any of this sounds familiar (in climbing or life), it's important to begin taking notice of just who is directing the actions you take on a daily basis. In many cases you'll discover that outside forces are calling the shots for you—that is, you are taking the actions someone else wants you to make, not those congruent with your goals. This is what the multibillion-dollar advertising industry is all about. Large companies spend millions with the sole intent of directing your actions in their favor (to make them money and drain your wallet). So while you might have a very worthy goal of, say, “getting out of debt” or “saving for a house,” advertisers cleverly divert your actions in their favor. Unless you are acutely aware of what's going on (and the power they wield over you), you will veer off your course and onto theirs—and maybe never reach your goals.

This may sound negative, but the same thing often happens when you're training at the gym or climbing at the crag. Instead of doing the precise exercises and drills you need to improve your weaknesses, you end up climbing down the blind alley of someone else's agenda. Consider how many

climbing days you've spent working on someone else's dream project (one that is either over your head or just not what you had planned) when you would have gained more by getting on a different type of climb. Or ponder how often you've gone to the gym and ended up socializing and just climbing mindlessly with no goal or direction. Sure, these kinds of evenings can be relaxing and fun once in a while, but on a regular basis they will not make you a better climber.

The win-win solution is to find a partner equally motivated to taking actions that will produce the fastest possible gains in ability. With this person you can evenly split the climbing time, so that you each can work effectively toward your goals. Unfortunately, in many partnerships one person makes all the calls and gets most of the benefits of the time spent training or climbing.

In summary, strive for hour-to-hour, day-to-day awareness of the “whats” and “whys” of the actions you are taking. By formulating short-term goals, as discussed earlier, you can best maintain your focus on the things you need to do to improve short term and advance toward your meaningful medium- and long-term goals. Finally, foster an acute awareness of the results you are getting from your actions. Peak performers are those who most rapidly recognize when they are off course and respond with a reassessment of the situation and an appropriate course correction toward the desired goal.

If it's beginning to sound like becoming a better climber is a very mental thing, you are right! So let's dive into chapter 3, “Mental Training.”

Tips for Achieving Your Goals

1. Know yourself. Live your passion. What worthy goals will drive you to excellence?
2. Regularly assess your strengths and weaknesses. What's holding you back in terms of action (or inaction) and self-defeating thoughts and habits?
3. Take the self-assessment in this chapter at least once per year, and consider getting the objective evaluation of a climbing coach.
4. Regularly evaluate the effectiveness of your actions—are you obtaining the intended results? If not, make course corrections that will yield more effective actions.
5. Don't be afraid to step away from the crowd and pursue your own mega goals. Ally with like-minded individuals, and avoid people with bad attitudes and unproductive behavior.
6. Set mega goals that will inspire and energize you from sunrise to sunset and, ultimately, make your life an amazing journey.



**B. J. Tilden killing the Big
Bad Wolf (5.14a), Wolf Point,
Wyoming. KYLE DUBA**